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-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-
"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

Govt panel wants ban on *Satluj* to stay, says film whitewashes terror

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 10

A GOVERNMENT panel reviewing "*Satluj*", which was pulled from OTT platform ZEE5 for viewers in India two days after its release on July 3, has recommended to the Information and Broadcasting (I&B) Ministry that the movie remain blocked from public access in the country, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The film, directed by Honey Trehan and starring Diljit Dosanjh, is set in Punjab during the tumultuous insurgency in the 1990s and is based on the life of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra, and shows his death in police custody in the wake of his campaign to probe hundreds of disappearances during the militancy years.

Sources said that the panel, the Inter-Departmental Committee (IDC), has invoked national security and told the Ministry that the film has the potential to threaten the security of the state. It is learnt that the IDC has said the film is appropriately covered under Section 69A of the IT Act.

It is learnt that the committee contended that the film

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

THE BIG PICTURE

JASWANT SINGH KHALRA: THE MAN WHO COUNTED THE MISSING PAGE 14

POLITICS PAGE 6

CENTRE CONSIDERS AMENDING IT RULES TO REGULATE FILMS ON ALL PLATFORMS

ETHANOL BLENDED PETROL PROGRAMME

E20 here to stay, giving choice not feasible: Govt

• **GOVT ADDRESSES QUESTIONS**

1 Why did India appear to rush its ethanol blending targets when Brazil took decades?

2 Why don't consumers have the choice of buying pure petrol, E10 or E20?

3 Why isn't E20 cheaper than E10 or pure petrol?

4 There are concerns E20 damages rubber components,

and many vehicle manuals specifically mention 'E10 compatible'.

May cut mileage by up to 5%, but is cleaner, superior in other performance parameters: Ministry

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 10

COUNTERING CRITICISM over its ethanol blended petrol programme, the government on Friday said while the current base fuel E20 — 80% petrol, 20% ethanol — can reduce fuel economy in some vehicles by 3-5%, it is cleaner and superior in other performance parameters vis-a-vis pure petrol and lower ethanol-petrol blends.

On consumers not getting the option to choose between pure petrol and ethanol-blended petrol of different blend levels, the government said that offering multiple grades of base fuel across the country would create an "enormous logistical challenge", apart from raising costs and reducing operational efficiency in the complex fuel retail network.

The government also argued that achieving 20% ethanol blending levels required massive investments, and going back to a lower blend level would not be prudent on various counts. India achieved 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year and the E20 fuel is currently the standard petrol variant across the country.

There has been public backlash over the E20 fuel, with claims ranging from reduction in mileage to engine component wear and tear in older vehicles whose engines were not designed for higher

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

TO MEET PM CHRISTOPHER LUXON TODAY

Modi first Indian PM to visit New Zealand in 40 years, trade and sports top agenda

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 10

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will meet New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon on Saturday, with talks focused on trade and investment, and high-tech innovation in dairying, farming and high-performance sports, sources said.

Modi arrived in Auckland on the final leg of his three-nation visit, where he was received by Luxon at the airport. This is the first visit to New Zealand by an Indian prime minister in 40 years.

Modi is slated to meet Luxon at Government House in Auckland for bilateral talks on Saturday. "Reached Auckland a short while ago. Thankful to Prime Minister Luxon for the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Indo-Pacific outreach

PM's NZ visit is part of Delhi's outreach to the Indo-Pacific countries, as China's assertive behaviour in the region has been a challenge. India has engaged with Japan, Australia and Indonesia in the last few weeks. New Zealand too is reaching out to India for expanding its market, which is part of its economic diversification.

SPORT PAGE 20

BIG BASH LEAGUE OPENER TO BE PLAYED IN CHENNAI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi being received by New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon in Auckland on Friday. ANI

SUSPECTED COLLUSION WITH PRIVATE BUYER

Diversion of rice meant for poor in North-East: 5 senior Food Corporation officials suspended

FCI Executive Director (Joint Secy-rank officer) among those under scrutiny

Shyamlal Yadav
New Delhi, July 10

FIVE OFFICIALS of the Food Corporation of India (FCI), including its Executive Director, have been suspended for alleged irregularities in the sale of rice meant for public distribution in the North Eastern states, *The Indian Express* has learned.

On July 6, the Department of Food and Public Distribution, under the Ministry, issued a suspension order against Ashutosh Joshi, FCI's Executive Director. Joshi, a 1994-batch Indian Audit and Accounts Service (IA&AS) officer — equivalent to Joint Secretary rank — who joined FCI in 2023, was suspended with immediate effect. Joshi was unavailable for comment.

The next day, FCI issued suspension orders for: Anupam Dubey, General Manager, FCI Headquarters, Delhi; Vikash Krishna, Deputy General Manager, FCI Headquarters, Delhi; and Brahm Prakash, Assistant General Manager, Gurugram.

These three suspension orders, issued by FCI Managing Director Rabindra Kumar Agarwal, state that disciplinary proceedings against the officers are related to the findings of a committee. Its probe, sources say, found alleged irregularities, including diversion, in the sale of

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

The Second Page

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

E20 here to stay

ethanol blends.

The government has been attempting to allay such fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles would be marginal, outweighed by benefits like higher octane rating, superior anti-knock characteristics, faster combustion, better pickup, smoother acceleration and cleaner engine operation. The government has also rejected claims that E20 fuel could damage engine components.

As reported on Friday, Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari had told The Indian Express that reports of vehicular damage being circulated on social media were "overblown" and part of a concerted "false narrative". He had said that while average mileage could dip as ethanol content increases, the West Asian crisis has shown that India must explore all alternatives to fossil fuel imports.

There have also been questions on why consumers were not being offered a choice between pure petrol, E10 and E20 fuels, as is the practice in some countries.

"...if a cleaner, faster and less-polluting fuel is available, why would we deliberately choose an inferior alternative? The suggestion that every petrol pump should stock pure petrol, E10 and E20 simultaneously also ignores the realities of India's fuel distribution network. India operates over one lakh retail outlets, supported by an extensive network of refineries, terminals, depots and pipelines. Maintaining multiple grades of base petrol across this vast supply chain would create an enormous logistical challenge, increase handling costs, complicate inventory management and reduce operational efficiency," the Petroleum Ministry said in a detailed note on Friday.

"Over the past several years, public sector banks have financed nearly Rs 1 lakh crore/yr of investments in ethanol production and associated infrastructure...If, after creating this capacity, we were to arbitrarily revert to E10, what happens to these investments? What happens to the surplus production capacity? What happens to thousands of crores invested by farmers, cooperatives, entrepreneurs, financial institutions and public sector companies in good faith based on a national policy? Public policy must balance consumer interest with energy security, environmental sustainability, farmer welfare and prudent use of national resources," the ministry said.

Seeking to dismiss concerns that ethanol blending in petrol was accelerated in haste, the ministry said the rollout was not based "on assumptions", but done after detailed consultations with automobile manufacturers and other stakeholders, and extensive testing and field validation covering engine durability, fuel systems, material compatibility, corrosion resistance, drivability, emissions and performance.

However, following the backlash, there are indications that introduction of higher blends of ethanol in petrol may be delayed by the government. On Tuesday, The Indian Express had reported that the government was likely to push back the proposed shift to E25 fuel.

In its note on Friday, the ministry reiterated that the ethanol-petrol blending programme dates back over two decades, and "nobody questioned ethanol as a fuel", given its use in various countries, including the US and Brazil. After languishing for about a decade, India's ethanol blending programme gathered pace over the past few years as the government made concerted efforts to ensure sufficient ethanol availability.

"When India decided to move towards higher ethanol blends, the automobile industry was involved at every stage. For E10 compatibility, manufacturers were consulted well in advance, as early as 2020-21. India achieved its E10 target in June 2022... For E20, an even more rigorous process was followed. Extensive consultations were held with automobile manufacturers, component suppliers, testing agencies and research institutions. The roadmap of the IMC (Inter-Ministerial Committee) had been in the public domain from 2021 and laid out a calibrated path to reaching E20," the ministry said.

"Had automobile manufacturers not been fully satisfied with the results, they would never have stood behind the product or honoured vehicle warranties. The fact that virtually every manufacturer today is honouring warranty for all vehicles (old or new) is because they have been part of the consultation. Further, Maruti Suzuki serviced 2.84 crore vehicles during FY 2025-26, including 1.5 crore older, non-E20-certified vehicles, and reported no E20-linked corrosion, abnormal wear or component-life damage. Hero MotoCorp has reported similar field experience. This real-world evidence is far more reliable than isolated anecdotes," it said.

According to the ministry, if E20 was damaging rubber components, fuel lines or engines, there would have been lakhs of warranty claims by vehicle owners, widespread component failures, and an avalanche of complaints across the country, which "has simply not happened". The government also assured that the ethanol supply chain is among the most tightly regulated fuel supply systems, and that ethanol and blended petrol conform to strict Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) specifications and undergo quality checks at every stage from the "distillery to the depot to the retail outlet".

"E20 is a safe, cleaner, proven and scientifically validated fuel that Indian consumers can use with confidence. Its quality, safety and compatibility have been validated and assured by all responsible stakeholders, including automobile manufacturers, testing and homologation agencies, oil marketing companies, and regulatory authorities. Consumers are therefore advised not to be misled by misinformation, scaremongering or unverified content circulating on social media," it said.

On pricing, the ministry said E20 is not necessarily cheaper because ethanol procurement prices are fixed at remunerative levels to support farmers and can exceed the cost of petrol when international crude prices are relatively low.

Modi in New Zealand

welcome at the airport," Modi said in a post on X.

"This visit is historic, being the first Prime Ministerial visit to New Zealand in four decades. I look forward to holding talks with Prime Minister Luxon and discussing the complete range of the India-NZ friendship. I will also be addressing a community programme tomorrow in Auckland," he said.

In a post on X, the Ministry of External Affairs said, "This historic visit is set to strengthen bilateral ties and unlock new avenues of cooperation across several areas especially trade, defence, sports, culture, education, and people-to-people exchanges."

Calling it a "special welcome in Auckland!", the Ministry said in another post that the iconic Sky Tower was illuminated to mark Modi's visit, "symbolising the friendship between our two countries". In his departure statement in New Delhi, Modi had said his visit would "meaningfully build" upon the strong momentum in India-New Zealand ties following Luxon's visit to India in March 2025.

Modi's visit comes at a significant time, following the recent signing of the India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA). The two sides had decided to start negotiations in March 2025, during Luxon's visit to India, and completed the FTA talks in April this year, signing the pact in a record 13-month span.

Bilateral trade with New Zealand currently stands at US$2.25 billion. With the FTA and an almost tariff-free business environment, officials said there is a strong likelihood of rapid trade growth. Both countries are also aiming to double their trade in goods and services by 2030, and the FTA's provision for US$20 billion in investment in India over the next 15 years is expected to drive stronger economic partnership, officials said.

The strategic and geopolitical backdrop to the visit is New Zealand's desire to diversify its economic partnerships, given its heavy dependence on a single market -- a space India is hoping to fill.

Technology and innovation, one of New Zealand's strong suits, will be a key focus of the visit. New Zealand spends roughly 1.5% of its GDP on R&D and has achieved excellence in sectors such as dairying, farming and high-performance sports.

"We are trying to partner with New Zealand to learn from their best practices and innovations to strengthen corresponding Indian sectors. New Zealand is in the process of launching Kiwifruit Action Plan, Apple and Pear Action Plan and Honey Action Plan in India; and setting up Centres of Excellence in Kiwifruit in Nagaland and in Uttarakhand," an official said.

"We are also discussing similar cooperation in sports through a Joint Action Plan in Sports," the official said, adding that Modi will attend sports and business engagements at the Viaduct Business Center. India and Australia also signed a sports cooperation roadmap during Modi's visit.

People-to-people ties will be another key aspect of the visit, with New Zealand home to around 3 lakh persons of Indian origin who share a strong connection with India and play an important role in the country's politics, economy and business. Modi will also address the Indian diaspora at a community programme.

Satluj

goes against the country's sovereignty and integrity, and provides fodder to hostile elements. The committee is learnt to have recommended that ZEE5 and the makers of the film take steps to identify and remove pirated versions of the film circulating online.

Trehan was not available for comment.

The IDC is a Government oversight panel under the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, which investigates public complaints and content violations on streaming and digital news platforms, and makes related recommendations to the I&B ministry.

It comprises representatives from the ministries of I&B; Home Affairs; Electronics and Information Technology; Women and Child Development; External Affairs; Defence; and Law and Justice, or other ministries and domain experts according to the requirement.

Khalra, who had been documenting the alleged illegal cremation of "unclaimed" bodies during Punjab's militancy years, was killed in police custody after weeks of torture. His investigation had earlier estimated that around 25,000 people had been secretly cremated across Punjab.

Khalra's disappearance prompted a Supreme Court-ordered CBI probe into his abduction and the alleged illegal cremations. In 2011, the Supreme Court upheld life imprisonment for five policemen for his murder.

The Indian Express had reported that the I&B Ministry had issued an interim order to ZEE5, invoking Section 69A of the IT Act, asking the OTT platform to take down the film, citing security concerns. Subsequently, ZEE5 complied with the order.

The Government had, meanwhile, referred the film to the IDC. According to sources, the IDC met at least twice this week before finalising its recommendation.

The panel is learnt to have noted that the film was based on true stories and real events, which nullifies the disclaimer by the makers that it is a work of fiction especially when the issue is related to national security.

Sources said this was also pointed out by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) when it had reviewed the film about four years ago.

Sources said the IDC felt the film presented a biased view of events in Punjab during the period depicted. The committee was of the view that the film omits the portrayal of insurgents and terrorism while depicting counterinsurgency action as state excesses and brutality, not as a lawful response to terrorism, and showcasing state agencies in a negative light.

Sources indicated that the IDC also objected to a scene depicting a government official making statements that lend credibility to allegations of mass atrocities against a community -- thereby providing fodder to hostile elements to fuel and spread separatist campaigns, ideology and secessionist propaganda.

The IDC has observed that the film portrays the assassination of a Chief Minister as a retaliatory act in response to extra-judicial killings by the police.

This depiction, the IDC is learnt to have noted, suggests a moral justification for the assassination, rather than associating it with a terrorist act linked to the Khalistani militant movement, and fails to acknowledge the involvement of known terrorist organisations.

The IDC noted that such a portrayal undermines state security and public order — and that such content can be misused by various non-state actors and extremist organisations based abroad. The panel is learnt to have decided against the option of editing certain parts of the film before its release.

Before the ZEE5 release, the makers of "Satluj" had applied for CBFC certification in 2022 under a different title, "Punjab 95". However, the makers did not comply with the 127 cuts and title change suggested by the censor board, and mounted a legal challenge in the Bombay High Court before withdrawing the plea.

ZEE5's takedown of the film had triggered widespread debate with political parties and the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) pushing for screening to be resumed and Dosanjh stating that he "had a feeling that something like this would happen".

OTT content is not regulated by the CBFC but covered under the provisions of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021. A code of ethics, which is part of the IT Rules, requires OTT platforms to avoid publishing content prohibited by law and to undertake age-based classification of content.

The Bombay High Court has placed an interim pan-India stay on Rules 9(1) and 9(3) of the IT Rules 2021, which required digital news media and online publishers to adhere to the "code of ethics" and a three-tier grievance redressal mechanism.

Section 69A of the IT Act has generated debate over the years about free speech and censorship, given its increasing use. While the Government has underlined its necessity for national security, critics say the process is opaque, heavily executive-driven, and prone to excessive censorship.

Under this section, data provided by the Government in Parliament shows, as many as 36,838 URLs were blocked between January 2018 and October 2023. The operative language of the section states that the Centre may issue directions for blocking when it is "necessary or expedient" to do so in the interest of sovereignty and integrity of India, defence of India, security of the State, friendly relations with foreign States, public order, or to prevent incitement to cognizable offences — the rules under it require reasons in writing and a defined procedure.

FCI

rice to the North Eastern Regional Agricultural Marketing Corporation Limited (NERAMAC) under the Open Market Sale Scheme (Domestic) by FCI's Delhi Region.

On May 25, K P Asha, General Manager, FCI Regional Office, Delhi was suspended. Her suspension order alleged that she "has committed serious derelictions of duty and administrative lapses while discharging her official responsibilities and failed to maintain the desired standards of operation in issue of Rice without auction to NERAMAC which is not covered under the current OMSS(D) Policy."

When contacted by *The Indian Express*, FCI Managing Director Rabindra Kumar Agarwal declined to comment. Sources said that action against additional officials is likely in the coming days. Minister for Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, under whom FCI falls, Pralhad Joshi was unavailable for comment.

Sources said rice earmarked for distribution to poor beneficiaries under the public distribution system in Assam and other North Eastern states was allegedly diverted and sold to a private entity in violation of government policy. Officials are suspected of colluding with the private buyer.

NERAMAC, a public sector enterprise under the Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER), had earlier suspended two of its officials in connection with the same case. On June 23 this year, NERAMAC announced the suspension of its Managing Director Bhaskar Barua (w.e.f. June 17) and Additional General Manager (Agribusiness & I/c Marketing) Anjal Kr. Dutta (w.e.f. June 18).

The Open Market Sale Scheme (Domestic) is a government initiative under which FCI sells surplus foodgrains through e-auctions at predetermined reserve prices to stabilise market prices and ensure steady supply.

EXPRESS special

Govt considers making certification mandatory for non-theatre films too

Proposal to amend IT rules comes amid row over *Satluj* pullout

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 10

An SGPC delegation takes out a march in support of *Satluj*, in Amritsar on Friday. RANA SIMRANJIT SINGH

THE CENTRE is contemplating amending the Information Technology Act to ensure that any movie which is available for public viewing on any platform has certification even if it's not meant for theatrical release, sources said.

The move, which has been under consideration for some time, has picked up momentum against the backdrop of the controversy over the abrupt removal of *Satluj* — a biopic on Punjab human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra, being played by singer-actor Diljit Dosanjh — from OTT platform ZEE5 last weekend.

The makers of the film, earlier titled *Punjab '95*, waged a long battle with the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) over 127 suggested cuts, which they refused to accept. As a result, the film never reached the cinemas and was released on ZEE5 without the cuts under the name *Satluj* on July 3.

However, two days after the OTT release, the movie was taken down by the OTT platform, citing "current developments".

The issue has become a political flashpoint in poll-bound Punjab with the ruling AAP and the Opposition Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) vehemently protesting the move.

While AAP has taken a strong public stance against the removal of the film from the OTT platform, blaming the BJP-led Central government, Akali Dal president Sukhbir Singh Badal has announced that his party will screen the film across villages and towns in Punjab to "educate the younger generation about the atrocities committed against the Sikh community during the Congress regime." Assembly polls are due in Punjab early next year.

With the issue gaining political colour, officials in the Information and Broadcasting Ministry said demand for change in the IT rules to make certification mandatory for movies that are available for public viewing, even if they are not for release on traditional platforms, has grown stronger.

"Since viewership has shifted from the traditional to OTT and other platforms, there is a proposal for the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology to regulate the content that is for public viewing," said an official.

According to sources, *Satluj* had come before the film certification board in 2022. The makers had challenged the CBFC's objections before the Bombay High Court in 2023, but later withdrew the petition.

"A communication was sent (by CBFC) to them (filmmakers) in May 2023 prohibiting its release, citing reasons. They went to the court initially, but later, after seeing the reasons given by the Board, they decided to withdraw the case," said the official.

"This may be because the producer felt the court would stall the film forever, or the producers may have filed the petition as a pressure tactic against CBFC but realised the gravity of the concerns already expressed by CBFC," the official said.

The Bombay High Court disposed of the case on January 7, 2025. "Since withdrawing the petition from the court in January 2025, the film producers never attempted to resolve these matters with CBFC," the official said.

Sources in the ministry said that although the filmmakers had not made any changes to the original movie, just changed the title to *Satluj,* ZEE5 claimed it was not aware of these developments (in 2022 and 2023) when the ministry sought an explanation.

Officials argue that the government has several reasons to ban the film. According to them, the dominant narrative of the film is that the State was responsible for mass killings, disappearances and illegal cremations. This moves beyond criticism of specific excesses and converts counter-insurgency into an alleged machinery of State oppression, the officials said.

Sources in the government said the current security context of Punjab makes the risk live, not historical, as Punjab remains a sensitive border state with continuing Khalistan-related propaganda, foreign-based separatist mobilisation and hostile information operations.

HC restrains EC from notifying bypolls to 5 TN seats until July 31

Bench: Issues arising from pending poll petitions require closer judicial scrutiny

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, July 10

THE MADRAS High Court on Friday restrained the Election Commission from issuing any notification for by-elections to the Tiruchi (East), Perundurai, Ambasamudram, Viralimalai and Karur Assembly constituencies until July 31, holding that issues arising from pending election petitions required closer judicial scrutiny before any further electoral process could be initiated.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G Arul Murugan passed the interim order on a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) filed by Tirunelveli-based advocate K Venkatachalapathy, who argued that the vacancies created by the resignation of the elected members could not automatically be treated as "clear vacancies" under Section 151-A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 because the election of those members had already been challenged before the High Court.

The court directed all the respondents to file comprehensive counteraffidavits within three weeks. "Till then, the first respondent/Election Commission of India is restrained from issuing any notification for a by-election in respect of the constituencies where the returned candidates resigned, as asserted in the writ petition," the court said.

According to the PIL, election petitions challenging the victories in all five constituencies seek not only to declare the returned candidates' elections void but also seek a declaration that the respective election petitioners should themselves be declared elected.

The petitioner argued that conducting bypolls before those petitions are decided could create a constitutional anomaly by producing two individuals with competing claims to represent the same constituency.

The Bench found prima facie support for that contention in earlier Supreme Court precedents. Quoting from D Sanjeevayya Vs Election Tribunal, the High Court observed that if a bypoll is conducted while an election petition seeking a declaration in favour of another candidate remains pending, "there will be two candidates representing the same constituency at the same time... and an impossible situation would arise". It further noted that the EC "is not bound... to hold a by-election forthwith but may suspend taking action... till the result of the election petition... is known."

The Bench also referred to subsequent Supreme Court rulings, including Election Commission vs Telangana Rashtra Samithi and Pramod Laxman Gudadhe v. Election Commission, which distinguished between vacancies where election petitions are pending and those where no such disputes exist. Summarising the legal position, the court observed that "a distinction must be drawn between two categories of vacancies" and that where an election petition seeking composite relief remains pending, "the vacancy cannot be treated as a 'clear vacancy' available for a bye-election."

During the hearing, Advocate General Vijay Narayan, appearing for the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly Secretary, argued that the dates on which the resignations took effect were significant. He contended that at least some resignations had been accepted before the corresponding election petitions were filed and therefore the vacancies had arisen before any election dispute was pending. He sought time to file a detailed counter affidavit on that issue. Senior counsel G Masilamani, appearing for Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, questioned the maintainability of the PIL and the petitioner's locus standi.

Kerala birth rate has reached an all-time low: 7 takeaways

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 10

KERALA'S CRUDE birth rate (CBR) has dropped into single digits for the first time, according to the vital statistics report of 2024 published by the state economics and statistics department. The data also shows that 2023 and 2024 recorded the sharpest back-to-back annual declines in the CBR in recent decades. Here are the key numbers:

CBR FALLS BELOW 10 FOR THE FIRST TIME: The state's CBR stood at 9.64 in 2024, down from 11.06 in 2023. CBR measures the total number of live births per 1,000 people in a population during a given year. For comparison, India's CBR, according to the Sample Registration System Statistical Report 2024, is 18.3.

LIVE BIRTHS DROP SHARPLY: The number of live births registered fell to 344,766 in 2024, down from 393,231 in 2023.

TWO CONSECUTIVE YEARS OF THE STEEPEST DECLINES ON RECORD: The CBR fell by 1.42 during 2023-24, following a decline of 1.47 during 2022-23. An analysis of Kerala's CBR since 1992 shows these are the sharpest annual declines in two consecutive years, indicating that the state's demographic transition – and its looming population crisis – has accelerated significantly.

A BRIEF POST-PANDEMIC REVERSAL IN 2022: The downward trend temporarily reversed in 2022, the year after the COVID-19 pandemic and lockdown. CBR rose from 11.94 in 2021 to 12.53 in 2022, an annual increase of 0.59, before resuming its decline.

THE TREND SINCE 1992: Kerala's CBR was 17.67 in 1992 and stayed around that level for several years. It slipped to 16.63 by 2006 and 15.75 by 2010. The rate fell below 15 for the first time in 2016, at 14.48, before dropping again to 13.79 in 2019. It then declined by 1.02 between 2019 and 2020, and by 0.83 between 2020 and 2021.

A NORTH-SOUTH DIVIDE IN DISTRICT-LEVEL BIRTH RATES: Alappuzha has the lowest CBR in the state at 5.28, followed by Kollam at 6.63. Central Kerala districts – Pathanamthitta, Idukki and Ernakulam – range between 9.30 and 7.69.

DEATH RATE STABILISES AFTER COVID-19 SPIKE: Kerala's crude death rate (CDR), which rose to 9.66 in 2021 and 9.16 in 2022 due to the pandemic, has since eased. The CDR stood at 8.77 in 2024, up slightly from 8.59 in 2023.

• PM TO FLAG OFF HYDROGEN TRAIN ON JULY 17

India joins elite group, only Japan, South Korea, the US and Canada have H-trains

Stations 12 | Distance 89 km | Travel time 2 hours

Operational speed **75 kmph** | Maximum Speed **120 kmph**

TRAIN TIMING

Train no 74010 Leave Jind railway station at **7.40 am** and arrive at Sonipat at **9.40 am**

Train no 74009 Leave Sonipat railway station at **10.40 am** and reach Jind at **1.00 pm**

Total seats 682 | Coaches 10

- Passenger capacity: **2,600**
- Power: **2400 kW**

Zero CO2 emissions and the only emission is water vapour

What is it?

Hydrogen trains, often referred to as 'hydrail' or 'H-trains' provide a viable alternative to diesel locomotives on non-electrified railway routes. The hydrogen fuel cells generate electricity chemically, meaning the only emission is harmless water vapour

> "The train will operate as a special inaugural service on July 17. The date for the commencement of its regular passenger service has not yet been decided,"
> SENIOR RAILWAY BOARD OFFICIAL

THE INDIAN EXPRESS

The Editorial Page

SATURDAY, JULY 11, 2026

Easing on China is right move at right time

IN 2019, India decided against joining RCEP, a trade agreement spanning 15 Asia-Pacific countries. A few months later, in April 2020, the Centre amended the FDI policy via Press Note 3, making government approval mandatory for investments from countries that share a land border with India. Both decisions were, in part, driven by concerns over China. But despite the ambiguity since then over the relationship with Beijing, trade ties between the two countries have deepened considerably. Imports from China touched $131 billion in 2025-26 and the country now accounts for roughly half of India's non-oil goods trade deficit. However, FDI from China has been minuscule. Since 2000, investment flows to India have added up to just $2.5 billion. The government has now approved a joint venture between Dixon Technologies and Vivo Mobile for manufacturing electronic devices and smartphones in the country. This is a step in the right direction.

In recent years, there has been a concerted attempt by multinationals to diversify away from China. India has, however, not been a significant beneficiary of the China+1 play, with countries like Vietnam benefiting more. The Economic Survey 2023-24 put forth two choices to benefit from the trade diversion away from China — either integrate more deeply with its supply chains or encourage greater FDI from the country. The Survey veered towards the latter option. In line with this thinking, in March this year, the Union cabinet approved changes to the FDI policy for investment from countries that share a land border with India in order to facilitate greater inflows. The approval of the joint venture between Dixon Technologies and Vivo Mobile and the waiver of customs duty on 85 goods used in manufacturing batteries, display assemblies and others comes only days after four Chinese power equipment manufacturing companies were reportedly allowed to take part in government tenders for critical power projects.

China is inextricably linked to the global manufacturing supply chain. That reality cannot be wished away. China is also a large source of FDI. As per the World Investment Report by UNCTAD, its outward investment "has become more targeted, with greater emphasis on greenfield projects, manufacturing, energy, infrastructure and critical raw materials, often in developing economies and along South-South investment corridors". While India has legitimate strategic and security concerns, there are also economic imperatives. A balance must be struck. The domestic manufacturing ecosystem must be deepened, and efforts stepped up to increase value addition and pursue closer integration with global supply chains. A careful and calibrated approach is needed.

Next leap will come from bringing AI and digital public infrastructure together

MANISH SABHARWAL AND RAVI BAPNA

THE FAILURE of multiple visits by the Japanese government to 111-year-old Sogen Kato's house to honour him — he was never home — had a simple explanation. He had been dead for 30 years while his family collected his pension. This triggered a national investigation that identified 3 lakh people who were assumed to be "living" but were dead. India's Aadhaar programme has reduced such pension scandals, improved the efficiency of government spending (up 117 times since 1991), and catalysed digital payments (42 per cent of the world's transactions). The next orbit for digital public infrastructure (DPI) lies in AI integration — it will raise state capacity and empower the new tone from the top on Jan Vishwas.

The last few years have been tough for Indian tech. We don't have a credible horse in the AI generation race, DeepSeek came out of China, and automated code generation has blunted the employment outlook for software services. But a recent conference at the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER) suggested optimism about this digital revolution of AI for three reasons. India is the world's largest natural data laboratory. Integrating DPI with AI could be the biggest reimagination of the Indian state since 1947. And AI deployment may be more employment-generative than AI generation. Let's look at all three in detail.

First, India has gone from data poor to data rich in just 10 years because of three bold acts of entrepreneurship in 2016: Jio, UPI, and GST. For decades, India's economic policy relied on periodic surveys and delayed, uneven and incomplete administrative data. But now, DPI's digital exhaust makes us the world's largest natural data laboratory for financial inclusion, welfare targeting, enterprise formalisation, platform economics and digital governance. UPI's monthly 23 billion transactions create one of the world's largest behavioural datasets. GST's 20 crore payments create real-time visibility into supply chains, invoicing, production and consumption. FASTag's 4.5 billion payment transactions create mobility and logistics datasets at scale. And, more than 27 billion annual Aadhaar authentications enabled a 16-fold expansion in direct benefit transfer beneficiaries. For the first time, a developing country is using population-scale digital data to accelerate development rather than waiting for conventional statistical systems to catch up. The job is hardly done — rigorous academic research, well-funded think tanks to bridge theory and practice, and open public data commons are just emerging — but the future seems very different from the past.

Second, India's political reimagination since 1947 has created the world's largest democracy on the infertile soil of the world's most hierarchical society. But why didn't we create the world's largest economy? Besides the delusional 1956 Second Five-Year Plan, weak state capacity is another suspect in our failed transition from farm to non-farm jobs. Historically, governments increased state capacity through more administrative structures and personnel (government spending has increased 53,000 times since the 1947 budget of Rs 198 crore). DPI enables better resource allocation, improved service delivery, earlier fraud detection, and quicker responses. But a reimagined citizen interface has been blunted by a lack of interoperability (digital silos are stronger than physical silos), the government's internal technology capacity, and a mentality that seems to be satisfied with PDFs, when the aim should be for APIs. AI's capacity to use unstructured data will help us leapfrog data integration and the interoperability challenges within our strong consent architecture and the recently articulated principles of Jan Vishwas Siddhant. Multiple language interfaces will open up labour and education markets, and AI will improve public health expenditure. India will be the first large country to integrate AI into population-scale DPI — America built AI on private-sector data ecosystems, and China built AI on platform-centric digital ecosystems. DPI without AI is infrastructure, and AI without DPI is intelligence. AI plus DPI is enhanced state capacity.

> DPI without AI is infrastructure, and AI without DPI is intelligence. AI plus DPI is enhanced state capacity

Finally, India's angst about AI's impact on jobs is understandable if it ends up with the winner-take-all characteristics of search or the fiery nationalism that halts access to frontier models — the recently-revoked restrictions on frontier AI models such as Claude 5, for instance. But deploying AI in the daily lives of citizens and companies requires more ingenuity, organisational savviness, and human capital than AI generation itself does. You don't have to build a car to drive it; let's build the roads (AI applications) that get people to extract economic and social value. The deployment of AI in DPI could make India the use-case capital of the world, not unlike the American state that used defence spending during the Cold War to catalyse Silicon Valley. India's enterprise DPI, currently under implementation (universal enterprise number, entity digilocker, API Setu, single source of truth for regulation), could potentially combine with a Universal Lifetime Social Security Account for every citizen (Aadhaar *punji*) to unleash a revolution in formalisation similar to what NPCI did in payments (private innovation on a non-profit layer). This would reduce information asymmetry, lower transaction costs, improve credit allocation and worker-job matching, enhance supply chain and logistics efficiency, and accelerate the creation of high-wage, private, non-farm jobs.

The *Arthashastra* suggests that strategy is most powerful when choices in strength, timing, and place are mutually reinforcing. Combining our strengths in DPI with the new tone from the top about Jan Vishwas (NCAER research suggests 66 per cent of connected Indians use the internet for entertainment but only 11 per cent for online government services), could deliver our new tryst with destiny: Higher state capacity, citizen satisfaction, and mass prosperity. And this is an appointment we shall keep.

Sabharwal is co-founder of Teamlease Services and co-author of Made in India. *Bapna is Curtis L Carlson Chair Professor in Business Analytics and Information Systems at University of Minnesota*

THE INDIAN EXPRESS

The Ideas Page

SATURDAY, JULY 11, 2026

You vote therefore you are: The hidden consequences of electoral deletion

SY QURAISHI

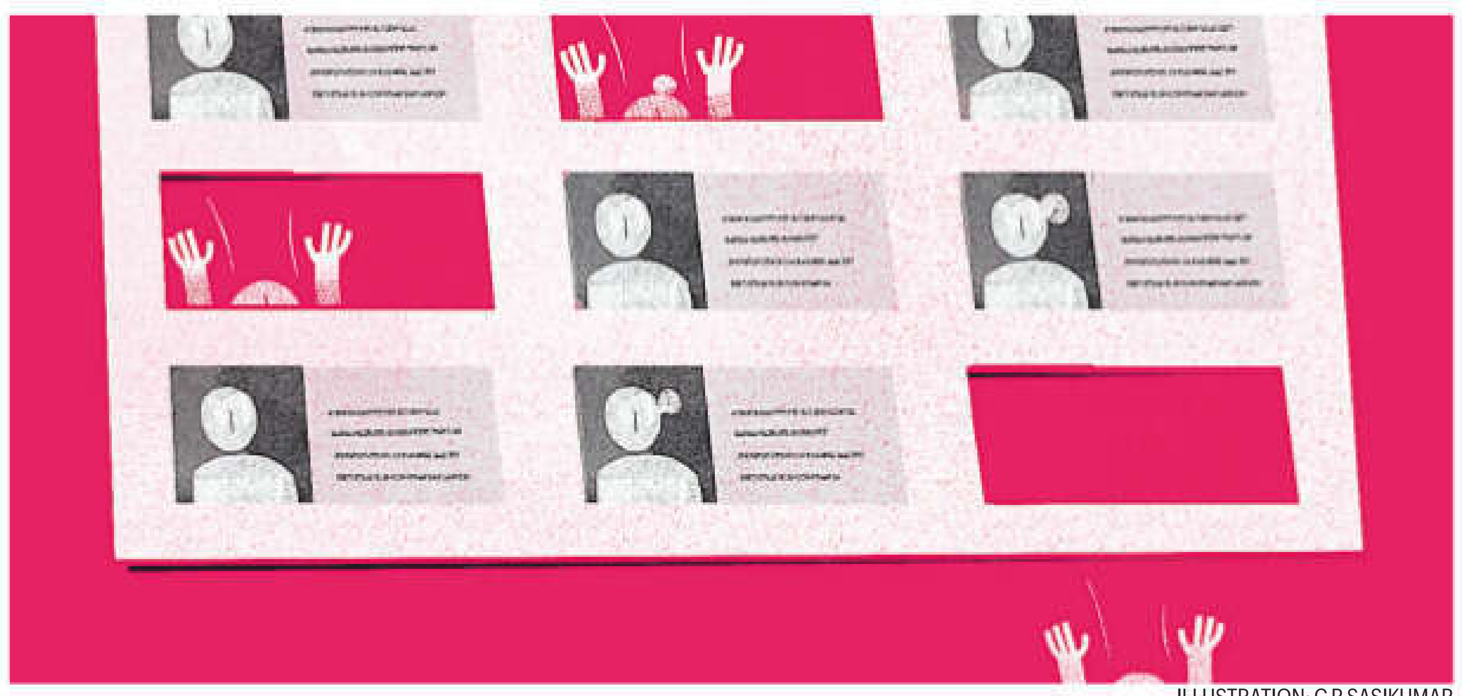


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

THE RECENT experience of R Rajagopal, former editor of *The Telegraph*, should worry every Indian citizen. Rajagopal has publicly stated that the renewal of his passport was held up after police verification because his name had been deleted from the electoral roll during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR). He received his renewed passport subsequently, but the fact remains: A distinguished journalist who had voted for decades suddenly found himself unable to obtain a passport because he no longer existed on the voters' list.

When reports of large-scale deletions from electoral rolls first began to emerge, the reaction of many citizens was surprisingly indifferent. "I never voted anyway," some remarked. "What difference does it make if my name is deleted?" Having spent years combating precisely this voter apathy through the Election Commission's SVEEP programme, I recognised the sentiment immediately. It reflected the widespread belief that deletion from the electoral roll meant nothing more than losing an opportunity that many had never exercised.

The Rajagopal episode exposes how mistaken that assumption may be.

The Election Commission has consistently assured the Supreme Court that the SIR is confined to preparing electoral rolls and that deletion carries no consequences beyond the right to vote. The Supreme Court, too, has reiterated that deletion from the electoral roll does not determine citizenship. The developments on the ground, however, suggest that this constitutional separation is beginning to erode.

An early cautionary lesson came from Assam. The National Register of Citizens was an exercise directly concerned with citizenship. Yet even there, exclusion from the NRC did not by itself result in loss of citizenship; any such determination could follow only after due process before the Foreigners' Tribunals. Even so, many families whose records became entangled in the NRC process found access to Aadhaar-linked services disrupted for years.

What, incidentally, are the welfare schemes? Subsidised food grain under the public distribution system, scholarships for students, old-age, widow and disability pensions, maternity benefits, LPG subsidies, housing assistance, health insurance, direct benefit transfers and even routine banking services. The lesson was simple: Although one government database was never intended to determine rights under another, administrative consequences often travelled far beyond the original purpose of the exercise.

That possibility has now become a harsher reality.

In Bihar, the consequences of electoral deletion have been stated with brazen candour. Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary said that persons deleted from the electoral roll "will not be entitled to any government benefits, including ration and other welfare schemes", and that "their bank passbooks will also be cancelled in due course of time." For the first time in independent India, deletion from the electoral roll has been publicly linked with exclusion from welfare benefits and even banking services.

West Bengal has moved in a similar direction. Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari declared that "no deceased person, illegal infiltrator or non-Indian individual will be allowed to avail government schemes". Food and Supplies Minister Ashok Kirtania stated that "those whose names have been deleted through the SIR cannot avail government schemes". Another minister added that persons deleted "are not citizens of the country or are dead… They cannot get the benefit of government schemes."

The Election Commission had assured the Supreme Court that the constitutional wall separating the electoral roll from other civic entitlements would remain intact. It is precisely that assurance which now appears to be under threat.

Assam, though not covered by the SIR, offers a different but equally instructive example — one that reveals the political purpose that electoral roll revision can come to serve. During the recent revision of electoral rolls, CM Himanta Biswa Sarma declared publicly: "My job is to make the Miya people suffer." He urged that Bengali-speaking Muslims be "troubled" "in any way" possible, adding: "Only if they face troubles will they leave Assam… We are saying it openly; we are not hiding it." He also announced that 4 to 5 lakh "Miya" voters would be deleted from Assam's electoral rolls and later explained: "I won't be able to deport them in my lifetime. That's why I keep pressuring them, so that they leave by themselves." It is the language not of an administrator updating electoral rolls but of a constitutional functionary presenting electoral deletion as an instrument of exclusion.

> The Supreme Court, too, has reiterated that deletion from the electoral roll does not determine citizenship. The developments on the ground, however, suggest that this constitutional separation is beginning to erode

If Bihar and West Bengal illustrate the expanding administrative consequences of electoral deletion, Assam illustrates something even more disturbing -- the political purpose that, in some quarters, is now openly attached to it.

Taken together, these developments reveal a pattern that should concern every constitutional democracy. A list prepared for the limited purpose of determining who may vote is quietly beginning to influence who may receive welfare benefits, banking services and travel documents. A clerical mistake, an absent migrant worker, a missed visit by a booth-level officer, or the inability to produce an old document can now trigger a chain of consequences extending far beyond the polling booth.

This is no longer merely about the right to vote. It is about the citizen's relationship with the state.

The electoral roll serves one constitutional purpose: Identifying those entitled to vote under Article 326. Welfare benefits flow from separate statutes. Banking relationships are governed by different laws. Passports are issued under an entirely different legal framework. Citizenship is determined under the Citizenship Act, not the Representation of the People Act. These legal boundaries exist to ensure that an administrative exercise designed for one objective does not become a mechanism for exclusion in entirely unrelated spheres of public life.

Once those boundaries begin to dissolve, the consequences become grave. A citizen deleted from one database may gradually discover that he has disappeared in many others. The case of R Rajagopal is therefore not merely the story of one journalist encountering bureaucratic difficulty. It is a warning to the republic. Those who once dismissed electoral deletion with a shrug — "I never voted anyway" — now have reason to think again. Their indifference rested on the belief that only the vote was at stake. That assumption no longer appears safe.

Electoral rolls are indispensable to free and fair elections. They must never become proxies for determining a citizen's entitlement to rights, services or benefits beyond the electoral process. The republic has always recognised a vital constitutional distinction between the right to vote and the broader rights of citizenship. That distinction now deserves to be reaffirmed — with clarity and without delay.

For, if deletion from the electoral roll is allowed to acquire consequences far beyond the franchise, the hidden cost of losing one's name from the voters' list may prove to be not merely the loss of a vote, but the beginning of a citizen's gradual disappearance from official existence.

The writer is former Chief Election Commissioner of India and author of An Undocumented Wonder: The Making of the Great Indian Election efficiency, and demanded that consumers be given the option to choose unblended petrol

Rice meant for ethanol production 'diverted' in MP

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 10

POLICE IN Madhya Pradesh are investigating the alleged diversion of government rice meant for an ethanol plant before it reached its destination.

To boost ethanol blending and reduce dependence on imported fossil fuels, the Union government has permitted surplus food grain, including rice held by the Food Corporation of India (FCI), to be supplied to ethanol manufacturers.

The probe in Madhya Pradesh centres on a consignment of the government's custom-milled rice (CMR), which investigators say never reached its destined ethanol plant in Chhindwara. Instead, officials found it parked inside a private rice mill in Waraseoni, where the accused "intended to recycle rice under the 2025-26 Custom Milling Programme and re-deposit it under the same scheme".

Police have alleged Rahul Pratap, an authorised representative of AVJ Agrico Pvt Ltd, "intended to divert the rice received from the FCI to a local rice mill and purchase cheaper rice for use in ethanol production at the Chhindwara ethanol plant, thereby causing direct financial loss to the Government". Police have also booked a truck driver, Durgesh Shendre, and Sancheti Rice Mill proprietor Saurabh Sancheti. Agrico Pvt Ltd and Sancheti Rice Mill did not respond to calls and messages seeking a comment.

Under the Open Market Sale Scheme (OMSS), only ethanol distilleries registered with Oil Marketing Companies and holding ethanol supply contracts are eligible to purchase FCI rice. The current reserve price for rice supplied for ethanol production is Rs 2,320 per quintal, below the government's estimated economic cost of procuring, milling, transporting and storing rice, which is Rs 4,100 per quintal.

"We have formed an SIT to probe the case. The allegations are being investigated," a senior police officer from Balaghat said. According to the investigation, records relating to paddy supplied for milling, stock verification, electricity consumption at rice mills, labour deployment and other operational indicators are being examined.

Investigators suspect that rice millers purchasing the government rice allegedly repacked it in fresh gunny bags and deposited it back into government warehouses as freshly produced Custom Milled Rice (CMR) under their milling contracts.

According to the police, the inquiry began after officials received information that "government rice meant for an ethanol plant had allegedly been diverted". Acting on the complaint, the Tahsildar, Naib Tehsildar and the Junior Supply Officer conducted a surprise inspection at Sancheti Rice Mill in Waraseoni.

Inside the mill premises, officials found a truck loaded with 490 bags containing 242.55 quintals of government rice. During the inspection, the truck driver told officials that the rice had been loaded from the FCI depot at Navegaon in Balaghat and was meant for an ethanol plant in Chhindwara's Borgaon.

According to his statement, he had not been given any documents relating to either the vehicle or the rice consignment when he left the depot. Since his residence was nearby, he told investigators that he had decided to halt for the night and continue the journey the following morning.

The proprietor of the rice mill, however, stated that the truck owner knew him and had parked the vehicle inside the mill because it was raining and the truck could be kept under the tin shed.

Officials subsequently seized both the truck and its cargo and handed them over to Waraseoni police.

The inquiry also drew on the statement of the FCI depot manager at Navegaon. According to investigators, the depot manager stated that the rice had been officially released under the government's ethanol scheme and handed over to the authorised representative of the ethanol company.

"After the rice leaves the FCI depot, there is no responsibility on the FCI to ensure its transportation to the ethanol plant," read the statement of FCI depot manager at Navegaon, as quoted in the FIR.

EXPRESS special

Crackdown on cybercrime: Rs 25,000 cr saved, Rs 323 cr refunded, e-Zero FIR rolled out

2.75 lakh URLs, 233 apps, 3,691 websites blocked in 5 years, MHA officials brief PM

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 10

CYBERFRAUD PREVENTION worth more than Rs 25,000 crore, a money restoration module to give refunds to victims and the rollout of an e-Zero FIR initiative were among the key points presented for the first time before Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his meeting with the secretaries of Central ministries last week, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

At the meeting, which lasted around four hours, PM Modi was informed that the union Ministry of Home Affairs had launched a new e-Zero FIR system last year. Under this system, cyber financial crime complaints lodged through the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal or the cyber helpline number 1930 are automatically converted into e-Zero FIRs if the reported loss exceeds Rs 10 lakh.

India recorded 98 lakh cybercrime complaints between

GETTY IMAGES

August 2019 and May 2026, while only 2.3 lakh FIRs were registered during the same period. This translates into an FIR conversion rate of 2.36%.

Currently, the e-Zero FIR initiative has been launched in Delhi, Haryana, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Goa, Chandigarh, West Bengal, Rajasthan and Assam. "PM Modi was informed that the process of implementing the e-Zero FIR initiative in at least 19 more states and union Territories is underway," a source said.

This was PM Modi's second major institutional interaction with top bureaucrats in less than two months. On May 21, he chaired a joint meeting of the union Council of Ministers and Central Secretaries to develop regulatory roadmaps to realise the vision of 'Viksit Bharat'.

At the meeting, the Home Ministry officials also briefed PM Modi that the Centre had blocked around 2.75 lakh URLs, 233 apps and 3,691 websites in the last five years for allegedly containing "material prejudicial to the sovereignty and integrity of India" under the Information Technology Act.

Between 2021 and May 2026, people reported cybercrime losses of Rs 64,447 crore. Of this, Rs 10,718 crore was frozen as lien. Only Rs 323 crore has been refunded to victims, a source said.

"Immediate interventions by the Centre have helped prevent fraud worth Rs 25,095 crore. Also, Rs 2.27 crore transactions were declined, around 12.1 lakh mule accounts were debit-frozen, and 31.6 lakh suspect identifiers were flagged with the help of the suspect registry," the source said.

The Home Ministry officials also informed the PM that 1,596 banks and financial institutions have been onboarded on the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal's Citizen Financial Cyber Frauds Reporting and Management System.

They briefed PM Modi on the ministry's plans, including setting up state and regional cybercrime coordination centres, and training police personnel to make them cyber commandos, a source said.

El Niño strengthens, could develop into strongest since 1950, says US agency

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, July 10

THE PREVAILING El Niño in the Pacific Ocean could turn into one of the largest events in history, US-based National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) said on Thursday.

"There is an 81 per cent chance of a very strong El Niño during October-December that would rank among the largest El Niño events in the historical record, going back to 1950," NOAA said in its monthly bulletin.

El Niño and La Niña are two phases of the El Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO), an ocean-atmosphere interaction. They can trigger extreme weather, droughts, and heatwaves across the globe. Over the Indian region, it can adversely affect rain. India is expected to see below-normal monsoon this year due to this. The ENSO phase and intensity of the El Niño and La Niña are decided by surface temperatures of a

E. EXPLAINED

El Niño and India

El Niño and La Niña are two phases of the El Niño Southern Oscillation , an ocean-atmosphere interaction. These events can trigger extreme weather, droughts, and heatwaves. Over the Indian region, it can adversely affect rain.

specific region of the Pacific Ocean, called the Niño 3.4 region. El Niño is declared only when the average sea surface temperature anomaly in this region surpasses 0.50°C .

The Niño 3.4 index has already crossed 1.2°C, stated the NOAA bulletin, but called it moderate. An El Niño is usually considered strong when the Niño 3.4 index crosses 1.5°C, and very strong when beyond 2°C. The strength of an El Niño phase also depends on its duration.

The strongest recent El Niño in was in the 2015-2016 period. Termed Godzilla, it persisted for almost two years (2014 to 2016) and broke several climate records. The Niño 3.4 index had remained above 2°C Celsius for well over four months. In India, that period had the top four driest years with monsoon rains fell below 90% of normal. Other very strong El Niño phases occurred in 1991-92, 1997-98, and 1982-83.

Even though El Niño events usually mature near winter, this year it has been intensifying since April-May, said Roxy Mathew Koll, climate scientist at Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology, Pune.

"The rapid strengthening of the current El Nino appears to be linked to a combination of oceanic and atmospheric conditions. Ocean dynamics increased subsurface temperatures in the eastern Pacific… provides the heat reservoir that can sustain and amplify surface warming…. weakened trade winds help push warm water eastward, further reinforcing… through ocean-atmosphere feedback," he said.

According to Mrutyunjay Mohapatra, director general, India Meteorological Department (IMD), strong El Nino can have a more adverse impact on rainfall. "In the past, 60 per cent of the El Nino years saw either below normal or deficient seasonal rainfall…" he said.

On July 9, IMD forecast a slightly below-normal rainfall over the country till July 22.

"With the monsoon trough shifting towards Himalayan foothills, rainfall over western India will reduce significantly," said IMD chief. Till July 22, normal rain is forecast for Rajasthan, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, and interior parts of north Karnataka. The current El Niño event began in June and is predicted to intensify and trickle into 2027.

• SCIENCE

Landslides: The need for early warning systems

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, July 10

THE LANDSLIDES in recent days in the Western Ghats and other parts of India have reignited discussions on the need for an early warning system for such events.

Creating warning systems

Landslides can indeed be predicted, at least in highly prone areas such as Wayanad — where a 2024 landslide killed more than 300 people. Early warning system can be installed for timely evacuations from danger zones. Such systems already work effectively in many countries.

In India, too, such systems have worked in the past. Barely two weeks before the 2024 landslides in Wayanad, a series of landslides in the hills of Munnar (further south in Kerala) saw no loss of life. This was partly because the Idukki district administration evacuated people on the advice of a team of researchers from Amrita University, who were testing an early warning system. Led by Maneesha Vinodini Ramesh, it is one of many groups developing such systems in collaboration with government agencies.

Range of models

Recently, Professor Dericks Praise Shukla and his team at IIT Mandi have unveiled their own landslide early warning system, which is in the process of getting validated with ongoing events in the Himalayan region. Shukla has been using a different methodology than those deployed by researchers at Amrita University. "They have installed a network of sensors at the high-risk sites, instruments like tilt meters, pressure gauges, accelerometers (to measure change in vibrations, ground movements, etc.) and the like. If these sensors report values beyond certain well-defined thresholds, then a warning is issued, and the administration can take action," he said.

"Scientifically, this is a very robust method, and gives plenty of lead time to plan and execute evacuations. This is how early warning systems are operating in other countries as well. The one limitation is that you get the information only about the slope where the instruments are installed, nothing about the neighbouring slope. Landslides are highly localised events," he said.

Shukla has been using a probabilistic forecasting method to track possibilities of landslides in the Himalayan region. His team has mapped vulnerable spots in the region using a satellite-based database of past events.

Since rainfall is one of the most common triggers, the team uses highly localised rainfall forecasts to model the probability of a landslide. Other relevant factors, like soil conditions, rock stability, extent of slope and population density, have to be fed into the model. "Very localised rainfall forecast is available only on that particular date or a day earlier. So, our method does not give a very long lead time. Once higher-resolution rainfall forecasts, which India Meteorological Department is working on, become available, landslide forecasts can be made much earlier," Shukla said.

"A comprehensive and effective early warning system for landslides can be prepared in about two years if resources and effort are properly dedicated to it. Within the areas prone to landslides, we must identify high-risk areas where landslides are frequent... Once this gets done, we can install sensors at selected sites," he said.

RISK ZONES

- IIT Mandi professor Dericks Praise Shukla said the north-western Himalayan region and parts of Manipur and Mizoram are vulnerable to landslides.
- Sikkim is relatively less vulnerable due to a less dense road network, which implies greater stability, he said.

• HEALTH

Why weekly diabetes shot could reshape treatment

India has one of the world's largest diabetes populations. Novo Nordisk's new injection offers a cost effective and convenient option for diabetics

ANONNA DUTT

DANISH PHARMACEUTICAL giant Novo Nordisk Thursday launched its once-a-week insulin shot in India that promises to make blood sugar control more convenient in one of the world's largest diabetes populations. Called icodec, the drug will be sold under the brand name Awiqli ("a weekly") for just Rs 261 per week. This is the world's first long-acting insulin shot that reduces injections from 365 days a year to 52 days.

How does it work?

For long-lasting effects, two key modifications were made to human insulin to develop insulin icodec.

FIRST, a fatty acid chain was added to increase its affinity to a protein in the blood called albumin. When a week's dose of insulin is delivered under the skin, this bonding with albumin creates an inactive depot of the drug. This bond is reversible and the drug is slowly released into the bloodstream throughout the week.

SECOND, three amino acid substitutions were made to lower the molecule's affinity to insulin receptors. Even after the molecule gets out of the albumin bond, the reduced affinity for insulin receptors means the drug gets used slowly. The reduced affinity does not reduce the potency of the drug.

"The impact of this drug is similar to that of any other insulin. The advantage for the patients, however, is that it would reduce the number of shots they have to take. This is likely to improve compliance as well," said Dr SV Madhu, professor of endocrinology at GTB Hospital, New Delhi.

Is icodec different from insulin?

Icodec is an insulin analogue — a genetically engineered version of human insulin — that increases its life within the body.

Before the discovery of insulin in 1921, a childhood diabetes diagnosis was fatal. Physicians prescribed starvation treatment — low-calorie diets with periods of fasting. "Patients with T1D [type 1 diabetes] were often kept in hospital for weeks or months at a time, while their calorie intake and glucose excretion were meticulously recorded," according to the *BMJ*. Initially, the insulin given to these patients came from extracts of mashed-up pig and cow pancreas. It was only in the 1960s, when the structure of insulin was discovered, that it could be manufactured. It became more widely available after recombinant technology — which can be used to alter the genetic code of a protein — was developed in the 1970s. Now, most insulin is commercially manufactured and altered to increase the duration it stays in the body or improve the way it is absorbed. Insulin icodec is one such development.

While everyone with type 1 diabetes needs insulin injections because their body does not produce the hormone, when it comes to the more common type 2, many can manage with pills. Yet, 25 to 30% of the people end up requiring insulin eventually.

Who is the drug meant for?

The drug is meant for two categories of diabetics:

FIRST, type 2 diabetics who have failed to achieve blood glucose control even with the highest doses of oral medicines

"Those living with diabetes for eight to ten years, with pills being unable to control the blood glucose levels, need to take insulin injections to prevent further complications. Yet, most of them are unwilling to switch to the shots. Initiating insulin early can prevent damage to the organs, nerve endings, and the eye," said Dr S K Wangnoo, head of endocrinology at Indraprastha Apollo Hospital, New Delhi. Even doctors show reluctance to start their patients on insulin treatments.

Dr Madhu said once patients do not meet blood glucose targets despite the maximum dose and combination of oral medications, they should immediately be moved to insulin, initially at a lower dose with oral pills before transitioning completely to insulin.

Vikrant Shrotriya, managing director of Novo Nordisk India, said: "Currently, there are six million people on insulin in India, but this number should at least be double. Insulin is a drug that is never abused and is very effective for the treatment of diabetes, yet people stay away from it. We are hoping that the convenience of using this drug would mean more and more people who are recommended insulin start using it."

SECOND, as background insulin for type 1 diabetics

Those with type 1 diabetes need a long-acting dose known as the basal dose, along with shots around the meal times known as the bolus dose, based on how many calories they consume. "People with type 2 diabetes would be the best fit for this drug. This is because people with type 1 diabetes already need to take the three doses a day; a fourth dose doesn't add too much burden. Plus, they typically see more fluctuations in their blood glucose levels and need to adjust their insulin doses accordingly. When I put out a survey two years ago, some women reached out to me and said that they needed to adjust the dose during menstruation. This type of flexibility is not possible with a weekly dose," said Dr V Mohan, chairman of Dr Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre, Chennai.

What about side effects?

The most common side effect of the medicine is hypoglycemia — a condition where the blood glucose levels fall too much — that can affect one in ten people. Dr Wangnoo, however, says this is the same level as seen with other daily insulin shots.

Dr Madhu says: "The reason people notice these episodes of hypoglycemia with insulin is that blood glucose levels are controlled for the first time with it. Even pills can cause episodes of hypoglycaemia, but when blood glucose levels are through the roof, the question of hypoglycemia does not arise."

How much does it cost?

The drug will cost Rs 261 per week. It will be available in two doses of pre-filled pens — a 700 ml unit costing Rs 2,611 and a 2,100 ml unit costing Rs 7,883. A patient usually needs around 70 units per week, which may need to be scaled up depending on need. "The Rs 261 per week cost is cheaper than the current price of other insulin analogues, which can cost anywhere between Rs 345 and 453 a week. This drug will essentially cost around Rs 50 a day," said Shrotriya.

How many people in India need it?

Currently, 101 million people are living with diabetes and 136 million with pre-diabetes. "While initially most of them would be managed with pills, after five years, say, 5% to 10% would need insulin shots. And, after 10 years, maybe 20% to 30%. Even if we consider that only 20% need it, the number would still stand at around 20 million. There would definitely be more use for the drug in type 2 diabetics because of the convenience of taking one shot and cost similar to other products in the market," said Dr Mohan.

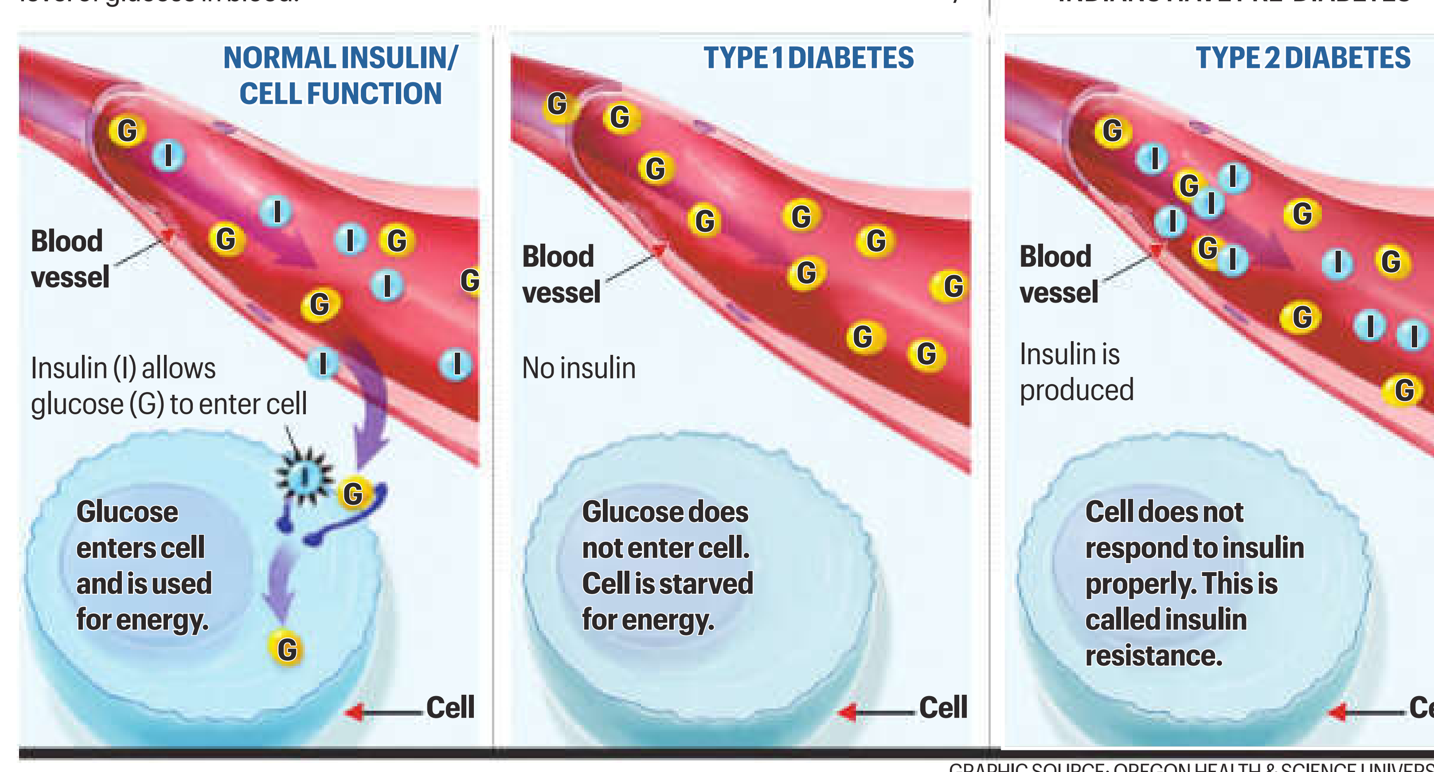
• HOW DIABETES TYPES 1 AND 2 AFFECT THE BODY

TYPE 1 DIABETES
A condition where the pancreas completely stops producing insulin, the hormone responsible for controlling the level of glucose in blood.

TYPE 2 DIABETES
Body's insulin production either goes down or the cells become resistant to the insulin. It accounts for more than 90% of all diabetes cases in the country.

101 million INDIANS ARE LIVING WITH DIABETES

136 million INDIANS HAVE PRE-DIABETES



GRAPHIC SOURCE: OREGON HEALTH & SCIENCE UNIVERSITY

Weight-loss drugs

Icodec, which lowers blood glucose levels, becomes more effective when combined with GLP-1 drugs.

•

This is because abdominal obesity, which GLP-1 tackles, reduces insulin sensitivity. Meaning, more insulin is needed to process same amount of sugar.

• ECONOMY

June inflation may breach RBI 4% target: Transport is driving this

GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES BY UDIT MISRA
WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

THE RETAIL inflation rate is set to breach the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) target level of 4%, according to an analysis by the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE). The next set of inflation data, covering June, will be released Monday.

Retail inflation fell sharply from more than 6% in October 2024 to zero in October 2025. Since then the figure has started edging up — a trend exacerbated by supply constraints in the wake of the West Asia war. Even so, retail inflation stayed below the RBI's target rate of 4% for the past 16 months. In May, the retail inflation was 3.93%. According to CMIE's estimates, the overall retail inflation in June is likely to be 4.25%.

Reasons for higher inflation

There are two main triggers for the anticipated jump in headline inflation rate, according to CMIE.

One, is the sub-category of "transport" inflation. In the overall index used to calculate inflation, this sub-category has a weight of around 9%. According to CMIE's estimates, transport inflation, which had largely been close to zero for most of this year, is likely to have grown by 4.6% in June.

This sharp spike in transport-related inflation (*see chart*) in June shows the full impact of the petrol and diesel price hike that were first implemented in May.

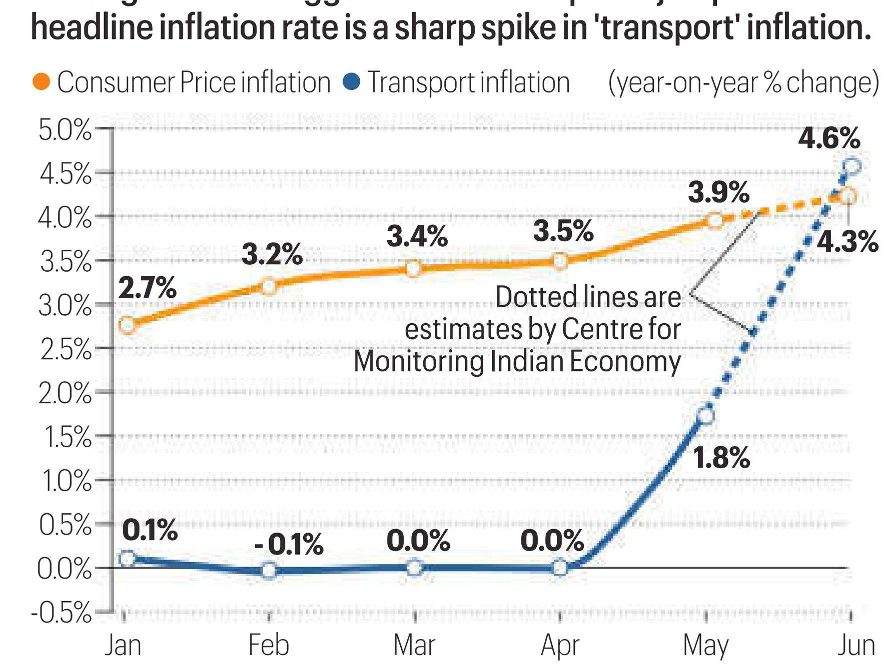
There are other factors that have likely pushed up transport costs. "...travel fares would have continued to rise, reflecting the higher fuel costs... Maruti raised vehicle prices from June to offset rising input costs. Inflation firmed across all components of the transport division, with the fuel price hike remaining the principal driver," notes CMIE's analysis.

The second sub-category that has experienced higher inflation in June has to do with different types of fuels. The government increased domestic LPG prices in early June, marking the second hike since March. LPG prices in June averaged Rs 947 per 14.2 kg cylinder across major cities, up from Rs 923 in May. Prices have cumulatively increased by more than Rs 80 since March.

"Higher LPG prices are also expected to have lifted the cost of substitute fuels such as firewood and dung cakes. Consequently, inflation in the electricity, gas, and other fuels category is estimated to have risen to 1.9 per cent from 0.8 per cent in May," says the CMIE analysis.

• A key inflation trigger: Transport

Among the main triggers for the anticipated jump in the headline inflation rate is a sharp spike in 'transport' inflation.



Impact on growth

Higher inflation is bad news for economic growth. Fast-rising prices drag down the real economic growth rate because they reduce a consumer's power to purchase goods and services with the same level of income. Things get worse when the RBI's policy action is taken into consideration.

At 4.25%, retail inflation would still be within the RBI's comfort band of 2% to 6%. If it stays within this zone, the RBI is unlikely to sharply calibrate its monetary policy.

But if inflation goes above 6%, for instance, the RBI will need to raise interest rates in the economy. This makes all kinds of loans costlier and, thus, makes it expensive for anyone to undertake any economic activity. Reduced economic activity reduces demand for goods and services in the economy, thereby cooling down price rise.

Given the renewed hostilities between US and Iran, the RBI will likely be cautious in the coming months if inflation keeps inching up. If the trend sustains, expect it to hike rates at some point during the year.

• LEGAL

Behind *Satluj* takedown, the parallel regimes for theatrical and OTT releases

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, July 10

AFTER BEING stuck for nearly three years over certification issues, the movie *Satluj*, based on the life of rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra, premiered on ZEE5 on July 3. Just two days later, however, it was taken off the platform. While the film remains available internationally on ZEE5 Global, it is unavailable in India "until further notice".

Government sources have cited "security concerns" over the film. An Inter-Departmental Committee, constituted by the government under the Information Technology Rules 2021, is set to take up the matter.

The takedown of a film that was never allowed a theatrical release has put the spotlight on the parallel regulatory regimes in India — the Cinematograph Act for theatrical releases and the Information Technology (IT) Rules, 2021 for streaming platforms.

Why was Satluj banned?

The film chronicles Khalra, the Amritsar-based activist, who investigated the alleged illegal cremation of "thousands of unidentified bodies" by police during Punjab's militancy years. He was abducted and killed in 1995, a case in which several police officials were convicted.

The project, originally titled *Ghallughara*, changed its name to *Punjab '95* after the first round of scrutiny by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC). The CBFC sought 127 cuts before it would clear a theatrical release, which the makers refused.

The film, therefore, never reached the cinemas and eventually landed on the over-the-top (OTT) platform — without the cuts — under the name *Satluj*. Parallelly, the makers challenged the CBFC's objections before the Bombay High Court in 2023, but later withdrew the petition.

How does CBFC certification work?

Theatre releases are governed by the Cinematograph Act, 1952. Under Section 4 of the Act, any person wishing to exhibit a film publicly must apply to the CBFC, a statutory body under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. Screening uncertified films in a cinema is a criminal offence.

The CBFC certifies films into categories: U (unrestricted); UA (unrestricted with parental guidance); A (adults only), and S (restricted to specialised audiences).

The Cinematograph (Amendment) Act, 2023, further split the UA category into age-based sub-categories and made certificates perpetually valid, removing the earlier 10-year limit. The Act also empowers the board to refuse certifications or to grant them subject to excisions and modifications if a film is against the interests of the sovereignty and integrity of India; the security of the state; friendly relations with foreign states; public order, decency or morality; or involves defamation or contempt of court. These are the "reasonable restrictions" on free speech under Article 19(2) of the Constitution.

Filmmakers have long criticised the wide discretion given to the examining and revising committee within the CBFC. Until 2021, a filmmaker, by a CBFC order in the form of a refusal or grant of a certificate or demands of cuts, could appeal to a dedicated tribunal under the act. A tribunal rationalisation reform abolished FCAT, transferring its functions to the High Courts, which is a slow and expensive process for time-sensitive releases. Critics also say that judges may lack the specialised engagement with cinema that a specialised tribunal would bring.

This is perhaps why the makers of Satluj withdrew the plea before the Bombay High Court and turned to streaming services where the CBFC has no jurisdiction.

How are OTT platforms regulated?

OTT platforms typically operated with minimal oversight. But as their influence and reach grew, the government has made attempts to regulate these platforms.

In 2019, the Karnataka High Court dismissed a writ petition seeking the regulation of content on OTT platforms also under the Cinematograph Act. The HC reiterated the distinction between public exhibition of films, which is governed under the Cinematograph Act, to a private viewing of content on an OTT platform by individuals in the privacy of their personal spaces.

The government had also opposed the plea, arguing that the provisions of the IT Act take care of the apprehensions expressed by the petitioner.

OTT content is regulated under part III of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, which prescribe a code of ethics requiring publishers to exercise caution over content that may fall under the grounds for "reasonable restrictions" mentioned above.

The rules set up a three-tier grievance structure — self-regulation by the publisher, self-regulatory bodies and government oversight through the Information and Broadcasting Ministry. This framework is also under challenge. The Bombay and Madras High Courts have stayed this provision.

In the 2023 Broadcasting Services (Regulation) Bill, which was subsequently withdrawn, the government attempted to define OTT platforms as a broadcasting service to bring them under its ambit.

In the case of *Satluj's* takedown, the government has reportedly used its powers under Section 69A of the IT Act.

What is Section 69A?

Section 69A involves the power to issue orders to block content. These orders are issued under the Information Technology (Procedure and Safeguards for Blocking Access of Information by Public) Rules, 2009. The government must record the reasons for blocking in writing, and then a designated review committee examines these directions and can set aside orders if they do not comply with Section 69A.

The Information & Broadcasting Ministry has formed an Inter-Departmental Committee under Rule 14 of the IT Rules to look into *Satluj's* content and make recommendations to the government. It can recommend warnings, an apology or disclaimer, reclassification or modification of content, or deletion and blocking under Section 69A.

KERALA ONLY MAJOR STATE LAGGING BEHIND, BUT NOT OPPOSED

Boost for labour reforms as West Bengal on board now

Ravi Dutta Mishra & Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 10

THE BJP's recent electoral gains has led to an upside for labour reforms. States that were holding out from implementing the long-pending labour codes are now coming on board. With a BJP government in place now, West Bengal, which lagged behind in framing the draft rules for the four labour codes, is getting ready to roll them out.

Opposition-ruled state Kerala is now the only major state that still remains out of the loop on the new labour codes and is yet to notify the rules, a senior government official said. However, Kerala is "not against" the implementation but is moving slowly in formalising the process for rollout of the four labour codes, the official added.

With the Congress-led UDF replacing the CPI(M)-led LDF government in Kerala, the official said the change in government could open the door somewhat as the state is "not against" the implementation of the labour codes and will open up to the benefits of the codes.

"West Bengal and Kerala are yet to notify the rules for the labour codes. But West Bengal is going to implement the codes soon. Kerala is the only major state that's left. It has said that it will assess the same but has not opposed it. That there could be challenges at the time of implementation of the new rules has been discussed with the states. The Centre has assured the states that it will resolve all queries," the official said.

The official pointed out that Karnataka, despite being an Opposition-ruled state, has accepted the codes and prepared the draft rules.

The Centre had notified the four labour codes — Code on Wages, 2019; Industrial Relations Code, 2020, Code on Social Security, 2020; and Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSH) Code, 2020 — in November 2025, close to five years after getting the law passed in Parliament. In December last year, the Ministry of Labour and Employment, in a written response, had said that states/ Union Territories are still in the process of finalising the rules, adding that 34 of the 36 states and Union Territories (UTs) had finalised the rules for the Code on Wages, Code on Social Security and Industrial Relations Code.

The Mamata Banerjee-led government in West Bengal had refused to comply with the labour codes, alleging that if the law was implemented, many workers would be deprived of social security.

Last December, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had also opposed the codes, saying they pose a threat to job security as the threshold for requiring prior government approval for layoffs had been raised from 100 to 300 workers, adding that companies would hire short-term workers to avoid giving benefits to long-term workers.

• ROAD AHEAD

WEST BENGAL, which lagged behind in framing the draft rules for the four labour codes, is getting ready to roll them out after the BJP government came to power

OPPOSITION-RULED Kerala is now the only major state that still remains out of the loop on the new labour codes and is yet to notify the rules. However, the state is "not against" the implementation

THE CENTRE had notified the four labour codes in November 2025. In December last year, the government had told that 34 of the 36 states and UTs had finalised the rules for the Code on Wages, Code on Social Security and Industrial Relations Code.

The Code on Wages seeks to redefine the break-up of wages to increase the share of the basic pay component — to enable higher provision for social security, especially in the service sector. The codes also aim to expand the social security provisions for gig workers.

While most states have finalised draft rules under the labour codes, as per the government reply in Parliament, the progress varied, depending on the government in power. For instance, BJP-ruled states like Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Assam finalised the draft rules in the first half of the year, but Opposition-ruled states like Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Telangana were slower. Labour laws fall under the concurrent list of the Constitution. Hence, both the Centre and states are empowered to make rules. But in the event of a conflict between state and central laws, central legislation generally takes precedence, unless the state's law has obtained presidential assent.

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